



CHAPTER XV

MOUNTAIN MEADOWS

1857

Henry came home from his mission after three years finding the situation in the peaceful settlement of Cedar City were much changed. Aside from the fact that Brigham Young advised them to move the site of the town once more, there had been a great drought, and there were other disconcerting things that had taken place. Henry had heard about them, but had not realized their full scope. While in Salt Lake City Henry reported to Brigham Young about seeing U.S. Government Troops on their way to Salt Lake City with the “intention of killing and destroying the saints of the Lord.”

Returning missionaries reported the murder of Parley P. Pratt near Fort Smith, Arkansas, by Hector McLean, a Unitarian minister who resented his wife’s conversion to the new and unpopular Mormon faith. He transferred his hatred of the Mormons toward Parley P. Pratt who was one of the most brilliant products of nineteenth-century Mormonism. What happened to Pratt in Arkansas affected many Mormons personally. His death, the first details of which filtered into the southern settlements during the closing days of July 1857, inspired sworn pledges to avenge his death, as well as to avenge the deaths of other Saints in Illinois and Missouri. It brought a shudder of horror throughout the territory, kindled fires of resentment and produced an

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atmosphere of fear in which reason was the first casualty. Pratt represented the best of the intellectual tradition of the territory, and the account of his death was not forgotten in the excitement of the impending federal invasion. He was among the first Saints to traverse the Great Plains to the Rockies and his extensive exploration of the southern rim of the Great Basin helped change Mormon colonization patterns. He combined a quiet privacy with a desire to become sensitive to the needs of his people. His genius was apparent in his ability to express himself, especially in his religious writings.¹

Two days after Henry dined with Wilford Woodruff in Salt Lake City, Woodruff wrote the following entry in his journal:

Sept. 29, 1857: Elder John D. Lee arrived from Harmony with an express and an awful tale of blood.

A company of California emigrants of about 150 men, women and children, many of them belonging to the mob in Missouri and Illinois [passed through Utah]. They had many cattle and horses. They wanted to do all the evil they could, so they poisoned beef and gave it to the Indians, and several of them died.

They poisoned the springs of water. Several of the Saints died. The Indians became enraged at their conduct and they surrounded them on a prairie and the emigrants formed a bulwark of their wagons and dug an entrenchment up to the hubs of their wagons, but the Indians fought them five days until they killed all their men, about 60 in number. They then rushed into their corral and cut the throats of their women and children except some eight or 10 children which they brought and sold to the whites.²

The Mountain Meadow Massacre had taken place September 8 through September 11. At this time, if President Young neglected to give the report of John D. Lee as much attention as it, perhaps, should have received, and if an investigation was not immediately instituted, there was ample excuse to be found in the circumstances of those

times. The U.S. Army was pressing upon the people uttering dire threats as to what would take place when it reached the valleys.³ Frustrated in seeking peace, bankrupting themselves to store food and ammunition, and struggling to reestablish uncompromising faith among themselves, the Saints observed the advance of the Utah Expedition. Brigham Young did not discount the rumor that "Squaw Killer," General Harney (the commander of the army expedition) was operating under orders to exterminate the Saints. President Young instructed his lieutenants, "The War-Hawks are abroad again and it becomes to us to prepare accordingly! Fix your guns for shooting if they are not already in that condition,"⁴

It is not known if Henry discussed the "Massacre" with his friends, John D. Lee, President Young or Wilford Woodruff, but he likely did in view of the fact that he was a Captain in the Nauvoo Legion and because of his prominence in the community. Henry's wife, Ellen, and her father, James Whittaker, would have been in Cedar City at the time the deed took place and would have brought the news to him when they arrived on October 5, 1857. Sister Isaac C. Haight was the President and Ellen was the Secretary of the Relief Society and the following was written in the minute book of that organization on September 10 (two days after the siege began):

Sister Haight said that these were squally times and we ought to attend to secret prayer in behalf of our husbands, sons, fathers, and brothers. The sisters were instructed to teach their sons and daughters the principle of righteousness and to implant a desire in their heart to avenge the blood of the Prophets.⁵

In retrospect, unaware of the critical events stirring in the western territory, a company led by Alexander Fancher, a farmer who had made two previous trips to the West, departed for California from Stiffler Spring, Arkansas, early on the morning of May 1, 1857, much in the manner of hundreds of other emigrant trains that would pass overland. The caravan was a fusion of various families drawn from the rich farmlands of the Mississippi Valley, assembled for mutual

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protection. As the train meandered across central Arkansas, it grew to more than forty wagons, including several hundred blooded horses and a thousand head of cattle; the total wealth of the caravan was \$70,000, by far one of the richest to cross the continent that year. Fancher had negotiated the purchase of a large tract of land in central California.

Sometime during the first week on the road, a band of self-styled "Missouri Wildcats" joined the original caravan. The Wildcats poisoned several springs along the trail and nothing was done to stop the unfortunate conduct of the Missourians. Fancher maintained a grave-like silence over the acts of violence. The Missourians proved to be a steady source of discomfort and difficulty, in fact it was said that the rest of the party could not sleep comfortably or feel safe in their company.

Rumors of the Missourians' hatred for the Mormons spread quickly. Eli B. Kelsey, a Saint who joined the party on the last leg of its journey to Salt Lake City "found the Wildcats in an unusually disagreeable mood, swearing vengeance against the Saints and generally making a nuisance out of themselves." Fearing serious trouble, Kelsey warned Captain Fancher that it was easy to provoke a difficulty; the whole country was excited over the news of the invading army. The advice was ignored. Upon reaching Salt Lake City, Utah, after purchasing supplies, the Fancher party camped on the west bank of the Jordan River. That evening Charles C. Rich arrived at the river camp to warn the caravan not to travel the southern road to California. Captain Fancher politely declined the advice, which, ultimately turned out to be an unwise decision.

With the Missourians leading the way, the wagon train proceeded through Springville, Payson and eventually to Fillmore where they found the Mormons unwilling to sell supplies, except for a few perishable foods. Other problems soon developed. The Missourians, greatly incensed by the Saint's refusal to trade, challenged the Mormons to stand their ground and fight at the same time damning the Mormons in a wicked manner, connecting the name of Deity with all their oaths. The "Wildcats" repeatedly expressed pleasure that the government had sent troops "to kill every G-damned Mormon in

Utah. They hoped they could do so and that they would like to help them to do the job."

A teamster boasted to the Mormons in Beaver that he had participated in the Hauns Mill Massacre in Missouri, an atrocity in which a mob wiped out a Mormon settlement. Another frontiersman claimed to be carrying the gun that killed Joseph Smith, and another proudly claimed that he was personally responsible for the death of Parley Pratt. The Mormons were further outraged by the sight of cattle tramping through their grain fields, teamsters popping the heads off their chickens with long bullwhips, and other acts of aggression against their farming settlements. The teamsters rudely called their lead oxen "Joseph Smith, Brigham Young, and Heber C. Kimball" after Mormon dignitaries.

The emigrants found the gates of the fort slammed shut against them at Parowan. The reluctance of local officials to sell them supplies was evidence that the word of the Missourians' conduct had preceded them. As the emigrants camped in the shadow of Parowan's walls, they drew the attention of William Leany, a village elder who had not taken seriously his instruction to refrain from selling supplies to wayfarers. Leany met the train near the outskirts of the settlement and was introduced to William Aden, a young artist with six months of frontier experience behind him. Less than a decade earlier, Leany had been saved from a mob by Aden's father while on a Church mission north of Paris, Tennessee. After a reunion that must have touched both men deeply, Aden followed Leany to his home, where they shared their experiences of the past years. At the end of the visit, Leany gave the young artist a supply of food and wished him a safe journey to California. But the poignant reunion angered the local authorities; three days later Leany was called out of his house and severely beaten (with a picket from his own fence) "by one of the local police on the charge that he had rendered 'aid and comfort to the enemy.' He was left for dead and indeed never did recover fully from the blow."

When the Fancher caravan reached Cedar City, the last large outpost of the Great Basin, the train was again refused provisions. Thwarted, the Missourians abandoned all pretexts of friendliness and

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rode into the heart of the town, fired indiscriminately at citizens at close quarters and wounded several residents. After a series of incidents with the local authorities, buildings, including the town's storehouse of grain, were broken open and robbed. As the caravan neared the outskirts of the village, an emigrant swung a pistol above his head and swore the weapon had killed "Joe Smith and had one bullet left for 'Old Brigham.'" Unprovoked and indiscriminate harassment increased throughout the night. At the emigrant bivouac three miles from the settlement, the travelers tore down fences and burned them for firewood, allowing five or six hundred animals to graze on unharvested crops.

The Cedar City police were incensed over the emigrants' lawlessness. After the company left the settlement, the frightened townspeople demanded that the military arrest the Missourians and bring them back to account for their crimes. The High Council convened on Sunday, September 6, to determine what action was to be taken. Some of the more radical members present suggested harsh measures (none, however, favoring any wholesale killing) and others were in favor of letting the thing pass and not bothering the company. Elias Morris suggested the idea of laying so important a matter before Brigham Young, and not taking any action until his judgement had been received. The council agreed to this suggestion, yet it was apparent that something had to be done to stop the emigrants from leaving their camp at Mountain Meadows, which was about 40 miles southwest of Cedar City, while John James Haslem, the emissary who agreed to obtain the decision, had time to ride to Salt Lake City to lay the case before Brigham Young.

To carry out the High Council's strategy, Colonel Haight, Pres. Of the Cedar Stake and second in command of the Iron County Militia, summoned John D. Lee who was over Indian affairs and gave him a long review of the events that had erupted within the community and declared that the Fancher party must be prevented from continuing to California. Haight told Major Lee to persuade some Paiute warriors to surround the Fancher train and maintain a siege until a new course of action was received from Salt Lake city. Lee returned to Harmony to collect a small Indian army for the assault.

Taking advantage of the predawn blackness the morning of September 8, the Indians slipped down a small ravine and mortally wounded more than ten emigrants before they could reach the safety of their wagons. The emigrants hurriedly heaped a wall of earth and rock between and under their wagons to stop the Paiute bullets and arrows.

While the assault continued the next two days, events took an ominous turn in Cedar City. Lee warned Haight by courier that he feared the Indians would turn against the Saints if the Fancher party's resistance was not soon broken. Perceiving the dilemma in military terms, he hesitantly ordered the Iron County militia to muster near the Old Fort while he went to Parowan and met with Colonel William H. Dame, the district military commander of the Nauvoo Legion.

It was past midnight, September 10, when the ranking officers of the Iron County Militia soberly reviewed the events of the past forty-eight hours. Colonel Dame tried to take control of the situation, despite conflicting advice on how to deal with the Indians and emigrants. Ultimately, the detachment started for the Meadows and increased its ranks up to fifty men as it rendezvoused with volunteers along the trail. The Indians joined in the slaughter and the party was killed except for some of the children. After it was over the Indians took shawls and bundles of clothing, guns or pistols, saddles and many of the cattle. The drama played to its conclusion on the morning of September 11, before Haslem returned from Salt Lake City on the 13th with Brigham Young's decision, longer than had been expected. The communique was clear and unmistakable:

In regard to emigration trains passing through our settlements we must not interfere with them until they are first notified to keep away, you must not meddle with them. The Indians we expect will do as they please, but you should try and preserve good feelings with them. There are no other trains going south that I know of. If those who are there will leave, just let them go in peace.⁶

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Fear and suspicion had taken a heavy toll. Important civil and church leaders scattered to the winds. A cloak of secrecy was thrown over southern Utah. The Mormons farmed out fifteen surviving children to households throughout the southern settlements until 1859 when the U.S. Military escorted them back to Arkansas.⁷

Less than four months after the calamity a mass exodus began from Cedar City, reducing its population to slightly more than twenty families in 1859. When questioned about the incident, the residents said, “We just don’t talk about it.”

It is an oversimplification to say that, “The Iron Mission suffered yet another setback!”

1. Donald R. Moorman, *Camp Floyd and The Mormons*, (Salt Lake City Utah: University of Utah Press, 1992), p. 126.
2. Wilford Woodruff, *Wilford Woodruff Journal*, S.U.U. Special Collections Library, Cedar City, Utah, Page 102.
3. Matthias F. Cowley, *Wilford Woodruff*, (Salt Lake City, Utah: Bookcraft, 1964), p. 388.
4. Donald R. Moorman, *op. cit.*, p. 127.
5. “Cedar City L.D.S. Ward Relief Society Minute Book,” Cedar City L.D.S. Genealogy Library.
6. Donald R. Moorman, *op. cit.*, p. 137.
7. *Ibid.*, page 144.

